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Just Like That

I made my way to the owners' boxes on the upper level. Or more appropriately, the owners' half-boxes. With so many stables in the league, space quickly becomes a problem and it's simply impossible to give each owner his or her own full suite. Partitions were used to divide each in half - doubling the number of available compartments while maintaining a fair amount of separate space for each group. And, since I don't travel with a *posse*, there's always plenty of room.

That didn't mean I was alone, though. With the entire RSI roster available to help out downstairs, Danni had elected to join me in the suite. After all, we both had our cell phones on us, and there was a hard line phone at the rear of the box, as well. If they needed to get in touch with us, they could.

There is one funny thing about these boxes. They may be luxurious, but they also put you pretty far away from the action. Not that it's all bad. The high angle takes the sides of the cage out of your sight line, and you can certainly see what's going on. But distance is distance, and being up here makes it pretty hard to see exactly what's going on. You end up watching the cage to see if anything's happening, then using the various video screens - both around the arena and in the box itself - to check the broadcast for the fine details.

A little buzz of activity erupted down on the floor, then the ring announcer's voice came loud and clear through the sound system as he read off the legal stuff. Sponsors, judges, sanctioning body... then finally he got to the fighters themselves.

"Introducing first... fighting out of the red corner and representing *God of War MMA Academy*... from Fountain Valley, California... she is... Keri RUS-SELL!"

Keri and her team entered the arena without a lot of fanfare. Some polite cheering from the fans, which she acknowledged quickly then made her way to the cage in no-nonsense fashion. Once her group was in position, the announcer continued.

"And her opponent... fighting out of the blue corner and representing *Rampage Sports, Incorporated*... from Seattle, Washington... she is... Dooooooooovvve CAMERON!"

Dove led the team out, with Steph, Jules and Marcy right behind her. She gave a little wave as she entered, but that was it. After that, her focus was straight forward, and she moved with surprising speed. Given her past performances, it was easy to assume she was driven by nerves. A desire to just get in there and get it over with. But the video feed told a different story. She looked... determined. Maybe even a little eager. She couldn't wait to get in there alright, but she didn't seem too worried about what would happen after the cage door closed.

The group reached their designated spot, and there was some last minute discussion as the announcer blew through the final necessities. More like instruction, actually. Jules had a hand on Dove's shoulder, but Steph was doing all the talking. Little reminders of whatever strategy they'd discussed. Not because Dove needed reminding, but because Steph wanted to get her charge into fight mode. A way of saying, *Forget*

everything else. Forget the waiting and the anticipation and the what-ifs. We're here now, and you know how to handle it.

She did it for everyone, whether they needed it or not. A comforting bit of routine. A reminder that, though you would be all on your own in this cage, you weren't really alone. You're team is behind you, and we'll all be here no matter what happens.

Dove nodded her way through it, still looking eager to get on with it. Then referee Autumn Reeser called the fighters to center. One last word from Steph and a quick shot of encouragement from Jules. Then the seconds cleared out as the fighters went out to meet each other for the first time.

The staredown was unremarkable. Both women were still early in their careers, and each had only one thing on her mind: *get the win*. So, neither seemed particularly interested in putting on some sort of act. They just wanted to get to work.

Reeser finished her spiel, sent them to opposite corners and called for the bell. Then the real show got started.

The first few exchanges were soft, with the two fencing a bit with their jabs. Easing into the fight and getting a feel for each other's range. Russell was the first to go a little bigger and try to combo off the jab, but her cross fell short when Dove backed out of range.

It went like that for a while, with both fighters playing it overwhelmingly conservative. The kind of action that can put the crowd to sleep. Dove earned a little pop when she doubled off the jab and landed a nice hook to her opponent's body, but Keri covered up and circled away before further damage could be done. Then it was back to the waiting game.

Despite the lack of action, I was impressed with what I was seeing from my fighter. While it's true that Dove was the only RSI rookie to get a win so far, even that performance was shaky. Her movements jumpy and unsure. The victory had only come because her opponent was even less confident than she was.

But that's not what I was seeing now. Though Russell had a lot of experience on her, Cameron did not look like she was in over her head. More importantly, she didn't look like she thought she was either. Not much was happening, but she looked like a fighter in control. Like she knew the lull was only temporary, but she was ready for anything.

She proved it only a few seconds later.

Keri came forward behind the one-two. Dove guarded the jab, slipped the cross and used her own jab to back the brunette off. And Keri did back up. Just one single step. Then she suddenly crouched low - her hands out and open. More like a freestyle wrestler than an MMA fighter.

Takedown!

While the move took me by surprise, it was not so for young Ms. Cameron. Russell's transition from boxer to wrestler took barely a second, but Dove matched her every step of the way. She got her head level with Keri's and got her hands out and ready. Feet spread for a steady base. Knees and elbows bent. Ready to receive. Keri sprang forward... right into the blonde's waiting defense. As Russell shot in, Dove used her head to push her off her line, got her hands onto the brunette's shoulders and pushed her right back out. Russell recovered immediately and shot in again. Dove was just as quick, but Russell was more determined this time. She brought her hands up and knocked Dove's away so she couldn't use them to push. The move was slick and fast, but, again, Cameron knew what to do. With her hands out of position, she got her elbows down and used her forearms to hold her opponent at bay. Her momentum halted, Keri tried to regroup for another push. Dove used that split-second to recover her hands and push the brunette out again.

The frustration of being denied twice showed as Russell went for a third try. She knocked Dove's hands aside again, then powered past the forearms. Putting Dove only an instant away from disaster. But there was no sign of panic in the RSI fighter as she moved to her last line of defense. A technique known as *hipping in*. Turning slightly, she slammed her right hip into the side of Russell's head. The shot not only stopped Keri's momentum but also knocked her off line. Undaunted, Russell immediately tried to gather herself for a final surge to finish the tackle. The basic rules of takedown defense called for Dove to use that brief period of adjustment to circle out and regain her defensive stance.

But that's not what she did.

What happened instead was a gorgeous combination of training and timing. Dove squared herself straight on with her opponent. As Keri pushed in, the RSI fighter started to turn - swinging her left leg out wide. Russell kept pushing, going after the stationary leg. But Dove kept turning, rotating behind and over Keri's back as she wrapped her right arm around the brunette's neck. Russell was left holding Dove's right foot while the rest of Ms. Cameron was hanging off her back. Keri's only remaining option was to test and see if the blonde was ticklish. Meanwhile, Dove sunk her arm in and started to strangle her opponent.

Recognition and terror washed over Keri's face in nearly instantaneous succession. The understanding of what Dove had done followed immediately by the knowledge that it was too late to do anything about it. Still, she had to try. She pried at Dove's arm as she moved to straighten up. Again, Cameron had the timing down. As soon as Keri started to rise, she gave a mighty heave and dragged them both down to the canvas - Dove on her back with Russell face up on top of her. Before Keri even knew what was happening, Dove had her legs hooked in. Nothing left for the blonde to do but squeeze with everything she had. Nothing left for Russell to do but tap or get choked out.

She wisely chose the former and Reeser immediately swooped in to break the hold as she called for the bell.

Barely ten seconds had passed since Russell's first takedown attempt, and now it was over. Just like that.

I gave Danni a wide-eyed look.

"Holy shit," I said.

She nodded knowingly.

"Amazing what you can learn when you actually apply yourself," she said.

The stunned expression never left my face as I realized how right she was. My eyes wandered to the video screen - the broadcast team going bonkers as they described the action on replay. I heard not a word they said. My attention was fully consumed by images of the calm and confident Dove. In a matter of mere seconds, she had produced her own how-to video on takedown defense, complete with a surprise twist for the ending.

Was this really the same young fighter I had effortlessly knocked flat just a few months ago?

"Holy shit," I said again as I looked back to the cage.

Both fighters were sitting up by then, and Russell was massaging her throat with both hands. Dove craned her head around so they could see each other, then said something that was clearly a variation of *You OK?* Russell responded with a solid but sullen nod. Dove gave her a little pat, then pushed back and cleared space for the medical staff to get in.

Her only celebration was a quick fist pump as she stood up. The epitome of *act like you've been there*. Then the seconds streamed in, and Jules raced right over and bearhugged her - happy to unleash the emotion Dove was working to keep bottled up.

After a quick exchange between the fellow bantamweights, Dove's head came up. It was soon obvious she was looking for someone, and she found her target when she spotted Steph. The blonde fighter started a wordless exchange between them with a single, subtle point of her finger. Steph nodded back as she approached.

Hmm.

Seems I'd missed an element in the recipe for Dove's tremendous reversal. Training, timing... and maybe just a pinch of foreknowledge?

It made sense. The move had been both stunning and elegant. Like it had been the moment Dove had been waiting for. My guess was that RSI's development coordinator had spotted something in Russell's game. A tendency to overcommit on her takedowns, it would seem. She passed the info on to Dove, along with a strategy for putting the knowledge to use.

Apparently, these rookies of ours were finally starting to understand the advantages Steph can bring them.

As for the move itself, full credit had to go to Cameron. It's not like it was something they'd rehearsed. She pulled that thing out of her hat all on her own.

Danni had also noticed the interaction between fighter and trainer, and had obviously drawn the same conclusion.

"Your people are good," she said.

I shook my head.

"No," I said without looking at her. "My people are the *best*."

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Another fun twist regarding tonight's event was that the RSI fights were all within just a few slots of one another. A positive because it meant there would be little waiting around once things got going, but also a negative because there would be very virtually no time to do anything between fights. So, with only one other contest on the schedule before Liv's turn came, there was no time for us to run downstairs and congratulate our young winner. Instead, I sent word for Ms. Cameron to call up to the box when she could, and that call came back within about twenty minutes.

"How 'bout that kid?" I said to her. "She really knows her shit."

Dove - now safely tucked away in the privacy of the RSI locker room - had lost the cool veneer and reverted back to her overenthusiastic teen-speak.

"Ohmygodthankyou!" she squealed. "That was SO totally awesome! I can't believe it!"

"You looked great out there," I said - though I'm not sure she heard me.

"Everyone's been so great and I've really been feeling more confident lately and I can't believe it worked like that even though Steph said it would and god it felt so great to..."

"Hey, hey! Woah!" I cut in. "Take a breath, would'ya?"

"I know. I'm sorry. I'm just excited!"

"Yeah, I can tell. And there's no reason you shouldn't be. But Liv's about to get started, so I need to get going. Danni's here with me. I'll put her on and you can screech at her for a while. I just want to say I'm proud of you. You worked hard, and it showed."

"Thanks!" she said. "And thanks for sticking with us!"

"You got it," I smiled.

I handed the phone to Danni and she'd barely said *hi* when I heard Dove's motor rev up again.

Danni's eyes went glassy for a moment, then she covered the mouthpiece with her hand.

"I hate you," she said flatly.

"Whatever," I replied.